

Narrative Design Document – Wizard Yan's Diary: The Remembrance Alchemy

Core narrative premise

Working narrative summary

In 18th-century Poland, the player takes the role of Rob, an otter-shaped familiar spirit summoned by the young wizard Yan. As they work together to uncover alchemical secret of resurrection, Rob begins recovering memories of a previous life as Robak, the legendary otter owned by Jan Chryzostom Pasek.

What begins as a student–teacher relationship gradually becomes a friendship, and Yan's tower becomes Rob's new home. But Rob's recovered memories complicate his sense of self: they reveal a life of companionship, captivity, escape, and death. As Rob questions whether he is Rob, Robak, or both, Yan confronts the reality that he is not Jan - and that resurrection may not be the right choice.

By the final act, the player has learned Rob's backstory and must decide what identity to embrace and whether to pursue resurrection. The ending is mechanically driven by the player's mastery of alchemy and memory system, where Rob's beliefs affect the ending.

Narrative pillars

Pillar 1: Memory vs identity

Narrative context: This is Rob's arc. Rob recovers memories of Robak, but does that make him Robak? Are the new memories he creates with Yan more important than his previous life? Are memories just a part of one's identity? If the understanding of a memory changes, does identity change along with it?

Gameplay translation: Memory system keeps track of Rob's memories and beliefs. These will change as the player progresses through the story, via discovering new memories and talking to Yan. The player can present a memory to Yan to discuss it, changing the way Rob perceives it, which may change his beliefs. The game culminates in player's choice, driven by Alchemy system: am I Rob or am I Robak? Do I want to be resurrected?

Pillar 2: Relationship and belonging

Narrative context: Throughout the game, Rob and Yan's relationship changes. At the beginning, they have a classic student/teacher relationship. A memory of happy life with Jan makes Rob resent Yan for summoning him. New memories of experimenting and playing together make Rob and Yan grow closer. Rob slowly starts to consider Yan's tower his new home.

Gameplay translation: Interacting with Yan creates new memories. Memory system allows the player to confront Yan on his hurtful comments, learning Yan's side of the story and preventing him from hurting Rob in the future interactions. Rob can decorate the tower with crafted items (toys, beds, etc.), which strengthens the belief that Yan's tower is his new home.

Pillar 3 - Opposing the authority

Narrative context: This is Jan's arc in the story. He allowed the king to take his pet otter, which led to its miserable life in captivity, and eventually death. Jan blames himself and spends the remainder of his life working on a spell that can bring back Robak, wishing he stood up to king's demands.

Gameplay translation: In the game, Jan's arc is explored through Memory system and talking with Yan. The player can decide whether they blame Jan for giving Robak to the king, if negotiating with the king was even an option, and if Jan's work, even if futile, makes up for the misery he had inflicted on Rob.

Pillar 4 – Perfectionism as maladaptation

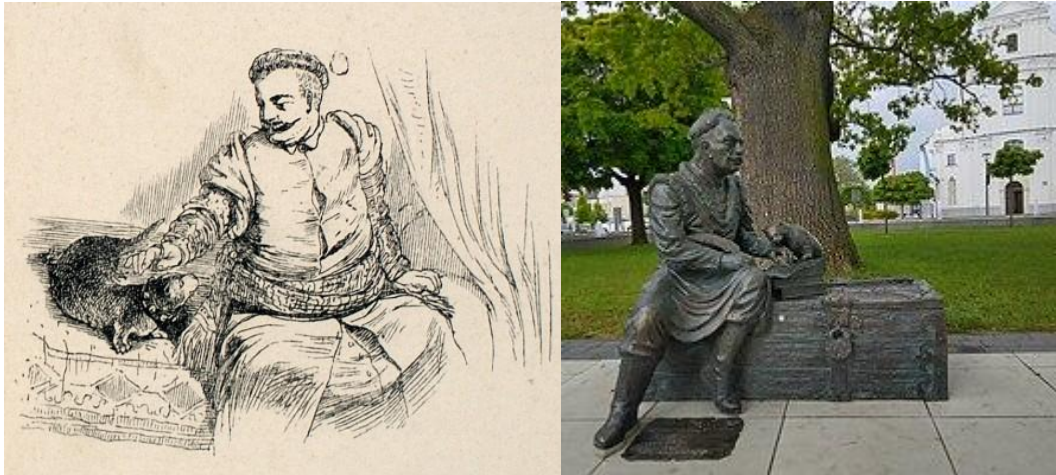
Narrative context: This is Yan's arc. The urge to do everything perfectly sends him into overanalyzing every possibility, makes him stuck in his comfort zone, and enables his inner critic, which also spills into his relationship with Rob. Rob shows Yan that experimentation and exploration can be fun, failing doesn't threaten his identity, and that progress is incompatible with perfectionism.

Gameplay translation: The alchemy system is built on the foundation of experimentation and exploration. Elemental space is literally an unexplored map with discoveries waiting to be unlocked. Failing an experiment has no negative consequences. The player is encouraged to experiment, formulate hypotheses and verify them.

Chronological story - outline

The story is split into two halves: the past and the present.

The past is based on a Diaries (1690–1695) of Jan Chryzostom Pasek, a Polish sarmate who owned a pet otter Robak. In the game, it will be uncovered through memories.



On the left, illustration by Antoni Zaleski

On the right, Jan and Robak's monument in Rawa Mazowiecka.

The present story follows a familiar Rob and a young wizard Yan, experienced in the game in real time through mechanics and narrative. It is structured around the six seasons of Poland: Early Spring, True Spring, Summer, Golden Autumn, Deep Autumn, and Winter. The game starts in Golden Autumn and ends the following Golden Autumn, making it 7 acts long.

The past

In 17th century Poland, Jan Chryzostom Pasek, infamously known as troublemaker and reveler, works for the king. On one of his missions, he travels through a forest and sets up a small camp with a campfire to cook fish he caught in a nearby lake. The smell of cooked fish draws in an otter. Jan offers the otter half a fish, which it eats voraciously. Although reluctant at first, the otter comes closer to Jan and allows him to pet it behind its ears. Jan adopts the otter and calls it Robak ("bug" in Polish).

The two become inseparable. Jan and Robak sleep together in one bed, Robak acts as an alarm clock and a guard. On command, Robak finds the closest source of water and brings fresh fish to be cooked. When anyone threatens their master, Robak attacks the aggressor with claws and teeth, horribly shrieking. Jan takes Robak with him on missions assigned by the king. Travelling is made easier with a constant supply of fresh fish, while other travelers are awestruck seeing Robak's tricks and their uncanny companionship.

The king learns about the incredible animal and demands Jan to give Robak to him. Jan outright refuses to part with his beloved otter. However, threatened by the king, he

eventually agrees. Robak is taken away to king's manor. The king makes the otter wear a bell collar, which Robak despises with every fiber of its being. Both the otter and Jan are heartbroken, being separated like this. Jan blames himself but feels powerless against king's will. Robak wants to escape, but his attempts are thwarted by the collar.

One day, Robak figures out a way to shed the bell collar and escapes the manor, looking for Jan. It runs through forests, swims across lakes and crosses numerous plains to finally reach Jan's home. On the final stretch to the door, an arrow, sent by an unaware hunter hoping to sell its fur, pierces the animal's body. Hearing the commotion, Jan runs outside to witness the final moments of his beloved pet.

Struck with grief and regret, he starts building a tower. He dedicates the rest of his life to studying alchemy, capable of resurrecting his Robak. Before his death, he records all his findings in a book "The Remembrance Alchemy", hoping someone in the future would be able to complete his research.

The present

In 18th century, a young ambitious wizard Yan moves into Jan's tower. The tower is mostly empty; the only remaining objects are the magical cauldron and Jan's book. Yan reads the book and decides to complete his predecessor's research. However, the book doesn't make sense to him, and his perfectionism keeps him from conducting even a single experiment.

The present – Golden Autumn

Yan decides to summon a familiar spirit for help. The ritual ends up summoning Robak's soul, lingering around the tower. Robak doesn't remember anything and is convinced that he's just a magical spirit. Yan names the familiar Rob and asks if Rob would like half of fish, which triggers a memory of meeting Jan. Unaware of Robak's history, Yan brushes it off as a symptom of the ritual.

With a helper, Yan attempts his first experiment, using a handful of ingredients he's found outside of the tower. Rob realizes that he can see ingredients' elemental energy, while Yan cannot. Yan hesitates for a long time, unsure which ingredient to add to the mixture. Rob decides for him, shaking him from analysis paralysis. Yan is angry at Rob and calls him "just a dumb familiar spirit, unaware of consequences of its actions". However, the experiment ends successfully. Yan is ashamed and explains that what he meant is that experiments could be dangerous and he was just worried about Rob and himself.

With Rob's ability to perceive elemental energy, Jan's book starts to finally make sense to Yan. Elemental space responds to ingredients elemental energy, moving a mixture through elemental space. With Rob's help, they draw Fire-Water axis and place

discovery zones from Jan's book onto a map, which allow the duo to discover new ingredients and objects that Rob can place around the tower.

Rob explores surroundings of his new home, finding new ingredients and discovering short memories of Robak's life. He starts to wonder if he's lived a life before being summoned by Yan, and what kind of life it was. In the meantime, Yan studies "The Remembrance Alchemy" and learns about enhancing ingredients' properties with the use of alchemical stations. Using Jan's notes, he discovers a new zone on the map. With Rob's help, the duo unlocks the first alchemical station and vector scaling.

Rob and Yan attempt the first alchemical exam, in which Rob demonstrates his knowledge of alchemy: how elemental space works and how ingredient's elemental energy is transformed into movement.

The present – Deep Autumn

Yan focuses on his research. Further study of alchemy reveals that there is another axis in elemental space – Air-Earth axis. The alchemy map transforms from a line into 2D space, revealing new discoveries.

Meanwhile, Rob ventures further away from the tower, finding a river. He gathers new ingredients. The river also reminds him that he used to be a male otter – his sprite transforms to otter-shaped. Happy memories of being an otter resurface – of fishing and playing with other otters in the river.

With new ingredients the duo goes back into experimenting with alchemy. They unlock a new processing station that allows them to refract ingredients through a magical crystal, altering its energies. At this point, an otter bed is craftable, placing it in the tower prompts a discussion between Rob and Yan about what a home is.

Another alchemical exam focuses on 2D elemental space and tests Rob's knowledge about processing stations.

The present - Winter

Rob visits a nearby town. Hearing a clock tower's bell fills him with dread, but he's yet unaware that it links to Robak's memories from captivity. By conversing with people, he learns that a king once had an otter and it was wearing a bell collar. He fantasizes what it would be like to be a king's pet, having servants and all the fish in the world. Revisiting previous locations in the winter reveals new ingredients and memories of playing in the snow.

Yan reflects on how perfectionism affects his work and relationship with Rob. He realizes that he's afraid of making a mistake. This, however, makes him stuck in the comfort zone. He wonders which is worse: to try and fail, or to never try in the first place.

Elemental zones are introduced in alchemy. Rob and Yan formulate hypotheses on how they might work. Yan starts treating Rob as an equal, moving away from student/teacher relationship and into friendship. One of the experiments results in bell collar, which triggers Rob's memory of being owned by the king. Rob starts questioning whether his previous life was as perfect as he imagined. He apologizes to Yan for resenting him for being summoned. Yan tries to console Rob.

The exam focuses on Rob's understanding of elemental zones, introducing multi-color elemental zones and long corridors.

The present – Early Spring

Rob visits previously unlocked locations after winter's passing. New memories reveal how Rob met Jan, how they shared fish, along with other memories from travelling together and protecting his master while he was asleep. Rob wonders if Jan was the king, and if so, why did he make Robak wear a bell collar.

Yan realizes that all remaining discovery zones are out of reach. He struggles to come up with a solution but is being interrupted and mocked by his inner critic. Rob encourages him to keep trying and assures him that even if his research is unsuccessful, they might still learn something new. With Rob's support Yan perseveres, and his research leads to discovery of fuel.

With fuel, experiments can use more ingredients, which allows for further exploration of the map. Rob tells Yan he's proud of him, while Yan thanks Rob for the support. Yan thinks back to their first experiment and apologizes for calling Rob a stupid familiar. He calls Rob his friend for the first time and asks what objects he would like to place in the tower, their home. They share a grilled fish, and Rob talks about his first encounter with Jan. Yan realizes that Rob's previous owner is the author of "The Remembrance Alchemy" and wonders whom he wanted to bring back through alchemy.

Exam tests Rob's ability to construct longer paths, utilizing the processing stations to reach far way points on the map. The last question in the exam points to Aether zone.

The present – True Spring

Rob travels to king's manor. Memories reveal that the king demanded Jan to hand over Robak to him. Rob realizes that Jan is not the king. Rob witnesses Robak's struggle to break free during the transport to the manor, how he bit king's hand upon arrival, how the king made him wear a bell collar, as well as the escape from the manor. The last memory shows Robak standing outside Jan's house and Jan opening the door to greet him. Rob believes that Yan summoned him at that exact moment, robbing him of finally returning to his beloved owner. He also wonders why Jan didn't fight for him or tried to rescue him from the manor.

Inspired by his own progress in alchemy, Yan reflects again on his perfectionism. Through an exchange with his inner critic, he realizes that it's better to try and fail than not to try at all. There's no other way to progress than through occasional failure. And failing itself also provides some new data to analyze. He says to his inner critic that he's grateful for trying to protect him, but he doesn't need him anymore. Yan wants to tell Rob he's changed his life, but Rob confronts him on stealing him from his owner, Jan. Yan responds that Jan is long gone. He documented his incomplete research in the book just before his death, hoping that someone in the future might finish it.

Aether zone discovered in the previous exam leads to a new layer of alchemy map, revealing new discoveries. Rob mourns the death of his owner but still can't believe he gave Robak away. Yan tries to cheer him up, revealing some discovery zones he found in Jan's book that were obviously meant for an otter companion – toy pebbles, magical waterhose, floating objects. He asks Rob if he remembers doing experiments with Jan and says that Jan must have really loved Robak.

The exam tests Rob's understanding of Aether zones, requiring discoveries from the new layer. The last question points to a descending Aether zone.

The present – Summer

Rob visits Jan's old home. Memories show that Robak was hit by an arrow, Jan ran outside to witness his Robak's final moments. Rob also witnesses the exchange between Jan and the king. The king threatens Jan, who's powerless and depressed after losing Robak. Revisiting already unlocked locations in summer yields some new ingredients. Rob reflects on the lifetime spent with Jan and new memories he made with Yan, questioning if he's Robak or Rob.

The descending Aether zone uncovers a new layer below the starting point.

Yan realizes Jan wanted to bring back Robak. He decides to continue his research, so that Rob can be resurrected. The new layer on the map contains a discovery area surrounded by impassable elemental zone. That's the final puzzle Jan couldn't solve. Yan reasons that there must be a way to bypass elemental zones somehow. He studies elemental energy of ingredients in hope of finding a solution. Yan is also seen reading medical books and sketching out otter's anatomy.

The exam asks Rob to explore the new layer. Passing the exam unlocks Aether processing mode for alchemical stations, which grant powerful options for late-game exploration.

The present – Golden Autumn

Rob discovers memories around the tower - of Jan building the tower, starting his research, his grief and frustration, working alone to bring back Robak, realizing he won't be able to complete his research and writing a book on his deathbed. Rob sympathizes with Jan. Even if he's resurrected, Jan is already gone. Will Rob keep Robak's and Rob's memories? Will he become a regular otter again, unable to see ingredients' energy or speak with Yan?

Yan's research on ingredients leads to discovery of magical monocle that allows him to see elemental energies, just like Rob. Looking at Rob, he notices he is giving off Aether energy. He hypothesizes that using him as an ingredient would allow for changing layers outside of Aether zones. This might be the way to reach the locked off discovery zone!

Reaching the discovery zone opens a wormhole, which displays a memory. Rob sees the other side and recognizes it immediately. It's his final memory before death. He sees Jan.

Yan: "Ah, so it's not resurrection, it's remembrance after all. Jan spent his lifetime searching for this memory. With Eather energy's transcending power, you should be able to enter it. Do you want to go back?"

Ending

The ending is mechanically driven. Throughout the game, Rob is collecting Robak's memories and creating new ones with Yan. When each memory is viewed, the player can respond to it in various ways, which shapes Rob's beliefs. If Rob identifies with Robak, he starts believing that he is Robak. If Rob identifies with Rob, he believes he is Rob. This creates four possibilities: (A) Robak, (B) Rob, (C) Robak and Rob, (D) neither. Depending on what Rob believes, a different ending is triggered.

Ending A – Robak

Robak: "That's me. My master is waiting. I'm going home."

Yan: "That's not your home, that's your death. Do you think this is what Jan wanted?"

Robak: "I am Robak. That's where I belong. I've seen all those memories, not knowing if they belong to me. Now I have a chance to actually experience one as Robak, even in those circumstances."

Yan: "... I don't understand. But I respect your decision, because I really care about you."

Robak: "... I'm sorry, I can't abandon my memories."

Yan: “What about memories we’ve made together? To me, you were Rob. And I won’t forget Rob.”

Robak: “I need to go.”

Yan: “I guess this is a goodbye, then. You were the best assistant I could have asked for. We’ve completed Jan’s research. I’ve learned so much from you and I’m going to miss you. Go, be with your master.”

Robak enters the wormhole. He’s dying. Jan holds his beloved otter in his arms. Robak feels Jan’s warm hands. He smells the familiar scent. He hears Jan crying and apologizing. Tears stream down Jan’s face and beard, onto Robak’s fur.

Robak dies. Jan is grieving. He builds a tower and begins his research. He writes “The Remembrance Alchemy” and dies shortly after. Decades pass.

Yan moves into the tower. He finds the book. He summons a familiar. Rob appears.

Rob: “Are you my master?”

Ending B – Rob

Rob and Yan watch the memory through a wormhole. They see Robak on the ground. Otter’s body is pierced with an arrow, with a pool of blood steadily growing beneath it. Jan rushes to Robak and holds him in his arms.

Yan: “This is heartbreaking. Jan must have replayed this memory thousands of times in his head. And then he spent the rest of his life trying to reach it. Why did he torture himself like that?”

Rob: “That’s the last time he’s seen Robak alive. Barely, but still. Imagine the amount of guilt he had to go through.”

Yan: “I can’t. I don’t know what I would do if I lost you.”

Rob: “...”

Yan: “...”

Yan: “So, what are you feeling, looking at this memory? Is that you?”

Rob: “That’s Robak. He died in that memory. We can’t bring him back. We are here because he died.”

Yan: “So it was all for nothing, eh?”

Rob: “We tried. We gathered new data. We’ve grown closer. It was worth it.”

Yan: “You’re right. It was definitely worth it.”

Rob: "I'm coming in. Keep the memory open."

Yan: "Wait, wha-"

Rob enters the wormhole. He remains a spirit. He sees Jan holding Robak in his arms, tears streaming down his face and beard, onto lifeless Robak's fur.

Jan: "I'm sorry, I'm so sorry..."

Rob reaches toward Jan, but his hand passes through him. He realizes he doesn't belong here. He comes back through the wormhole.

Yan: "So?"

Rob: "He was loved."

Yan: "Robak?"

Rob: "Yes. And Yan, too. Imagine escaping from your prison and going at such length to return to someone. Robak wasn't blaming Jan."

Yan: "What about you?"

Rob: "I..."

Rob looks around the tower. At their alchemy equipment, the ridiculous pile of ingredients they've made together. At his bed. He closes "The Remembrance Alchemy" and sets it in the bookshelf.

Rob: "I am here."

Ending C – Robak and Rob

Reaching the discovery zone creates a wormhole. Robak sees the other side and recognizes it immediately. It's his final memory before death. He sees Jan.

Yan: "Ah so it's remembrance, not resurrection. Jan wanted to preserve this memory. That's what I thought. Well, should we?"

Rob: "Wait, we? Are you coming with me?"

Yan: "My research suggests that it should be possible. Aether energy is about crossing boundaries. I can't leave my dear Rob to die, now can I?"

Rob: "What do you intent to do?"

Yan: "I've been studying otter anatomy all Summer, I think I can save you."

Rob: "...What if you can't?"

Yan: "I will give it my best anyway. That's what you taught me, right?"

Yan grabs scrolls and tools. Rob and Yan enter the wormhole. Robak is dying. Jan holds his beloved otter in his hands.

Yan: "We don't have much time. You have to trust me. Lay him gently on the ground."

Jan: "Where did you come from? Are you sure this will work?"

Yan freezes. Then he takes a breath and looks at his notes.

Yan: "No."

Beat.

Yan: "But we have to try."

The screen fades to black.

Jan is holding Robak. Robak's eyes slowly open. He looks at Jan. Then he looks at Yan. Jan gives Robak some fish. The otter eats half of it and nudges the other half towards Yan.

Ending D – Neither

Rob and Yan watch the memory through a wormhole. They see Robak on the ground. Otter's body is pierced with an arrow, with a pool of blood steadily growing beneath it. Jan rushes to Robak and holds him in his arms.

Yan: "This is heartbreaking. Jan must have replayed this memory thousands of times in his head. And then he spent the rest of his life trying to reach it. Why did he torture himself like that?"

Rob: "That's the last time he's seen Robak alive. Barely, but still. Imagine the amount of guilt he had to go through."

Yan: "I can't... So, what are you feeling, looking at this memory? Is that you?"

Rob: "No, that's Robak."

Yan: "But you remember it."

Rob: "I remember it. That's different".

Rob looks at himself.

Rob: "I'm a familiar spirit. You summoned me to help you with your research."

Yan: "Rob..."

Rob: "The research is completed. My job is done."

Yan: "..."

Rob: "You don't need me anymore. You should release me."

Yan: "...I don't want to. I still need your help with other research."

Rob: "That's not why you summoned me."

Yan: "You think this means you have to leave?"

Rob: "What else would I do?"

Yan: "...If that's what you wish for, I won't stand in your way."

Yan performs the ritual. The familiar bond begins to dissolve. Rob start becoming transparent.

Yan: "Will you remember me?"

Rob: "I think so."

Yan "Will you remember this place?"

Rob looks around the tower.

Rob: "Probably"

Yan: "Then why leave?"

Rob: "Because remembering something doesn't mean I have to belong to it."

Rob disappears. Yan is left alone in the tower. He looks around at the objects he's created with Rob. He picks up "The Remembrance Alchemy", closes the book and sets it on the bookshelf. He gets up, leaves the tower and walks outside.